

Assignment 6

Ling 201 – Spring 2026

(100 pts total)

Part 1. Presupposition Triggers

For each sentence, identify **one** definite expression it contains and state the presupposition brought about by the definite expression. Then identify one **other** presupposition trigger, identify the type of trigger, and state the presupposition it triggers.

1. Beryl started reading the paper.

definite expression: Beryl
presupposition: someone named Beryl exists
other presupposition trigger: start
trigger type: change-of-state verb
presupposition: Beryl was not previously reading the paper

2. Jeongjae texted my brother again.

definite expression: Jeongjae, my brother
presupposition: someone named Jeongjae exists, my brother exists
other presupposition trigger: again
trigger type: iterative expression
presupposition: Jeongjae has previously texted my brother

3. She realized that she had won the lottery.

definite expression: she, the lottery
presupposition: a female person exists, the lottery exists
other presupposition trigger: realised
trigger type: factive verb
presupposition: she had won the lottery

4. What Aidan wanted was a new job.

definite expression: Aidan
presupposition: someone named Aidan exists
other presupposition trigger: cleft sentence: "what X was Y"
trigger type: cleft
presupposition: Aidan wanted something

Part 2. Conversational Implicatures

For each conversation, identify the **conversational implicature** in Merlin's utterance. Then state the **flouted conversational maxim** (Quantity, Quality, Relevance, Manner) that leads to the implicature and **explain why** that Maxim is relevant.

1. **Arthur:** I could really go for a coffee.

Merlin: There's a café down the street.

implicature: Arthur can get a coffee at the café down the street

maxim: relevance/relation

explanation:

the relationship between coffee and the café is not explicitly stated, so we have to assume that Merlin intends Arthur to understand they can get a coffee at the café

2. **Arthur:** I'm going to spend all of my savings on videogames.

Merlin (unimpressed): What a great idea!

implicature: Merlin does not think it is a good idea

maxim: quality

explanation:

Merlin is flouting Quality for the sake of sarcasm; we assume that Merlin intends Arthur to understand he is not being sincere, and that he does not in fact think it is a great idea

3. **Arthur:** Did you do the reading for phonology class?

Merlin: I read the first page.

implicature: Merlin did not do the entire reading

maxim: quantity

explanation:

Merlin did not answer Arthur's question fully; if he is cooperative in the conversation, it is probably because he did not finish the reading and doesn't want to admit it

4. **Arthur:** Why is your face all red?

Merlin: I put on some lotion and got a rash.

implicature: because Merlin put on some lotion, he got a rash

maxim: manner

explanation:

actually this one is not flouted, but following the maxim of manner, Merlin is telling the events intentionally in the order in which they happened, in which case his intended message would be that he put on some lotion *and then* got a rash; if he is also implying a cause-and-effect relationship between these events, then her intended message would be that *because* he put on the lotion, *therefore* he got a rash

5. **Arthur:** Are you going to the beach this weekend?

Merlin: It's going to be chilly.

implicature: Arthur is not going to the beach because it will be cold

maxim: relevance

explanation:

a connection between going to the beach and cold temperature is not explicitly stated. If we assume that Merlin is cooperative, we have to find some connection between these ideas. Since we know people tend to prefer going to the beach when it's warm, we can assume that Merlin's intended message is he is not going to the beach because it will be too cold

Part 3. Entailments vs. Implicatures

For each statement in (a), an **entailment** and an **implicature** are given. **Identify** which is which, and **explain** your answer using the cancellation **OR** reinforcement test.

1. (a) Vinny finished today's work.

(b) Vinny worked today.

(c) Vinny will not work more today.

(b) is an **entailment** of the sentence (a), and if sentence (a) is true, sentence (b) must be true as well. It cannot be **cancelled** by saying "Vinny finished today's work. Actually, he does not work today." This sentence is **contradictory** and does not make sense, which suggests that (c) is not an implicature but an **entailment**

(c) is an **implicature** of the sentence (a), and it can be **cancelled** by saying "Vinny finished today's work. Actually, he is going to do tomorrow's work as well." This sentence makes sense and cancels (c), which suggests that (c) is an **implicature**

2. (a) Even I can solve the puzzle.

(b) The puzzle is easy to solve.

(c) I can solve the puzzle.

(b) is an **implicature** of the sentence (a), and it can be **cancelled** by saying "Even I can solve the puzzle, although it is not actually an easy puzzle." This sentence makes sense and cancels (b), which suggests that (b) is an **implicature**

(c) is an **entailment** of the sentence (a), and if sentence (a) is true, sentence (c) must be true as well. It cannot be **cancelled** by saying "Even I can solve the puzzle. Actually, I cannot solve the puzzle." This sentence is **contradictory** and does not make sense, which suggests that (c) is not an implicature but an **entailment**

3. (a) Utku forgot to switch off the stove.
(b) Utku didn't switch off the stove.
(c) Utku was supposed to switch off the stove.

(b) is an **entailment** of the sentence (a), and if sentence (a) is true, sentence (b) must be true as well. It cannot be **cancelled** by saying "Utku forgot to switch off the stove. Actually, he switched off the stove." This sentence is **contradictory** and does not make sense, which suggests that (b) is not an implicature but an **entailment**

(c) is an **implicature** of the sentence (a), and it can be **cancelled** by saying "Utku forgot to switch off the stove, Actually, he was not supposed to but someone else was." This sentence makes sense and cancels (c), which suggests that (c) is an **implicature**

4. (a) Surprisingly, Fahad came to the party.
(b) We did not expect that Fahad would come.
(c) Fahad came to the party.

(b) is an **implicature** of the sentence (a), and it can be **cancelled** by saying "Surprisingly, Fahad came to the party. Actually we forgot that we did sent him an invitation." This sentence makes sense and cancels (b), which suggests that (b) is an **implicature**

(c) is an **entailment** of the sentence (a), and if sentence (a) is true, sentence (c) must be true as well. It cannot be **cancelled** by saying "Surprisingly, Fahad came to the party. Actually, Fahad did not come to the party." This sentence is **contradictory** and does not make sense, which suggests that (c) is not an implicature but an **entailment**

5. (a) The newest model is the cheapest of all models.
(b) The older models are more expensive.
(c) The newest model is a good deal.

(b) is an **entailment** of the sentence (a), and if sentence (a) is true, sentence (b) must be true as well. It cannot be **cancelled** by saying "The newest model is the cheapest of all models. Actually, the older models are never more expensive." This sentence is **contradictory** and does not make sense, which suggests that (b) is not an implicature but an **entailment**

(c) is an **implicature** of the sentence (a), and it can be **cancelled** by saying "The newest model is the cheapest of all models, although it is not actually a good deal still." This sentence makes sense and cancels (c), which suggests that (c) is an **implicature**

6. (a) Quartz and Tetsu had dinner and went to a movie.
(b) They ate a meal.
(c) They had dinner first and went to a movie second.

(b) is an **entailment** of the sentence (a), and if sentence (a) is true, sentence (b) must be true as well. It cannot be **cancelled** by saying "*Quartz and Tetsu had dinner and went to a movie. Actually, they did not eat a meal.*" This sentence is **contradictory** and does not make sense, which suggests that (c) is not an implicature but an **entailment**

(c) is an **implicature** of the sentence (a), and it can be **cancelled** by saying "*Quartz and Tetsu had dinner and went to a movie. Actually, they went to the movie first.*" This sentence makes sense and cancels (c), which suggests that (c) is an **implicature**

Part 4 Real-life Implicature

Imagine that Merlin and Arthur have a plan to throw Lancelot a surprise party at work. It is Merlin's job to meet Lancelot for lunch at a local restaurant to get him out of the office, and Arthur's job to decorate as soon as he leaves. Merlin phones Arthur and says, "The eagle has landed."
What Maxim is Merlin flouting? What does his utterance implicate?

When Merlin says, "The eagle has landed," he is violating the maxims of relevance and manner. Lancelot, then, has to choose whether to interpret Merlin's comment literally as a completely irrelevant comment or realise that Merlin is violating the maxim of relevance (by talking about eagles) and manner (but not saying directly and clearly what he means) intentionally, in order to be secretive. This type of talking in code works best when all parties involved have previously agreed upon the meanings of certain encoded phrases. Otherwise, even if the receiving party, like Lancelot in our example, recognizes the utterance as encoded, he won't be able to decode it!

(puzzle taken from Fromkin textbook)

Extra Credit

Here is a dialog excerpt from the 1945 motion picture *The Thin Man Goes Home*. The scene is in a shop that sells painting and Nick Charles is leaving the shop.

NICK CHARLES: Well, thank you very much. Goodbye now.

SHOPKEEPER: I beg your pardon?

NICK CHARLES: I said, goodbye now.

SHOPKEEPER: “Goodbye now?” There’s no sense to that! Obviously
it’s now! I mean, you wouldn’t say “goodbye tomorrow”
or “goodbye two hours ago!”

NICK CHARLES: You got hold of somethin’ there, brother.

SHOPKEEPER: I’ve got hold of some...I haven’t got hold of anything...
And I’m not your brother!

Analyse this dialogue, intended to be humorous (one assumes), in light of Grice’s maxims.

The shopkeeper seems to be unwilling (or unable) to interpret intended meanings of utterances that violate Grice’s maxims. For example, Nick Charles’ statement “goodbye now” violates the maxim of quantity, since the “now” part is obvious and redundant, but this violation probably would not bother most people. The shopkeeper, though, is quite bothered and points out this violation. Likewise, when Nick Charles calls the shopkeeper “brother,” he is violating the maxim of quality, since this isn’t technically true. Charles means it metaphorically, however, but the shopkeeper again can’t or won’t interpret it that way and again points out the violation. Metaphor, in general, seems to upset the shopkeeper, who also appears to interpret “You got hold of somethin’ there” only in its literal sense.